Family planning

***p. 142** Wynne-Edwards … has been mainly responsible for promulgating the idea of group selection.*

Wynne-Edwards is generally treated more kindly than academic heretics often are. By being wrong in an unequivocal way, he is widely credited (though I personally think this point is rather overdone) with having provoked people into thinking more clearly about selection. He himself made a magnanimous recantation in 1978, when he wrote:

> The general consensus of theoretical biologists at present is that credible models cannot be devised, by which the slow march of group selection could overtake the much faster spread of selfish genes that bring gains in individual fitness. I therefore accept their opinion.

Magnanimous these second thoughts may have been, but unfortunately he has had third ones: his latest book re-recants.

Group selection, in the sense in which we have all long understood it, is even more out of favour among biologists than it was when my first edition was published. You could be forgiven for thinking the opposite: a generation has grown up, especially in America, that scatters the name ‘group selection’ around like confetti. It is littered over all kinds of cases that used to be (and by the rest of us still are) clearly and straightforwardly understood as something else, say kin selection. I suppose it is futile to become too annoyed by such semantic parvenus. Nevertheless, the whole issue of group selection was very satisfactorily settled a decade ago by John Maynard Smith and others, and it is irritating to find that we are now two generations, as well as two nations, divided only by a common language. It is particularly unfortunate that philosophers, now belatedly entering the field, have started out muddled by this recent caprice of terminology. I recommend Alan Grafen’s essay ‘Natural Selection, Kin Selection and Group Selection’ as a clear-thinking, and I hope now definitive, sorting out of the neo-group-selection problem.